Military Two-seaters

Two-seaters were built in large numbers, enabling the pilot to concentrate on flying while the observer fired on enemy targets, dropped bombs, or carried out reconnaissance of enemy activity. At first, basic, unarmed aircraft were used, but as fighters and antiaircraft guns became more effective, more powerful engines were fitted, and personal sidearms gave way to machine guns. Some aircraft even had heated flying suits and radio communications.

▷ Royal Aircraft Factory B.E.2c 1912

Origin UK

Engine 90 hp Royal Aircraft Factory 1a air-cooled V8

Top speed 75 mph (120 km/h)

Some 3,500 of this slow but stable reconnaissance and light bombing machine were built. In 1914 the observer gained a machine gun, but by 1916 the aircraft was dangerously outdated.

◁ Royal Aircraft Factory F.E.2 1915

Origin UK

Engine 120–160 hp Beardmore water-cooled 6-cylinder in-line

Top speed 92 mph (147 km/h)

Originally intended as a fighter, the "pusher" F.E.2 was technically obsolete from the start. However, its observer had a wide field of fire and it was a success as a light bomber. More than 2,000 were built.

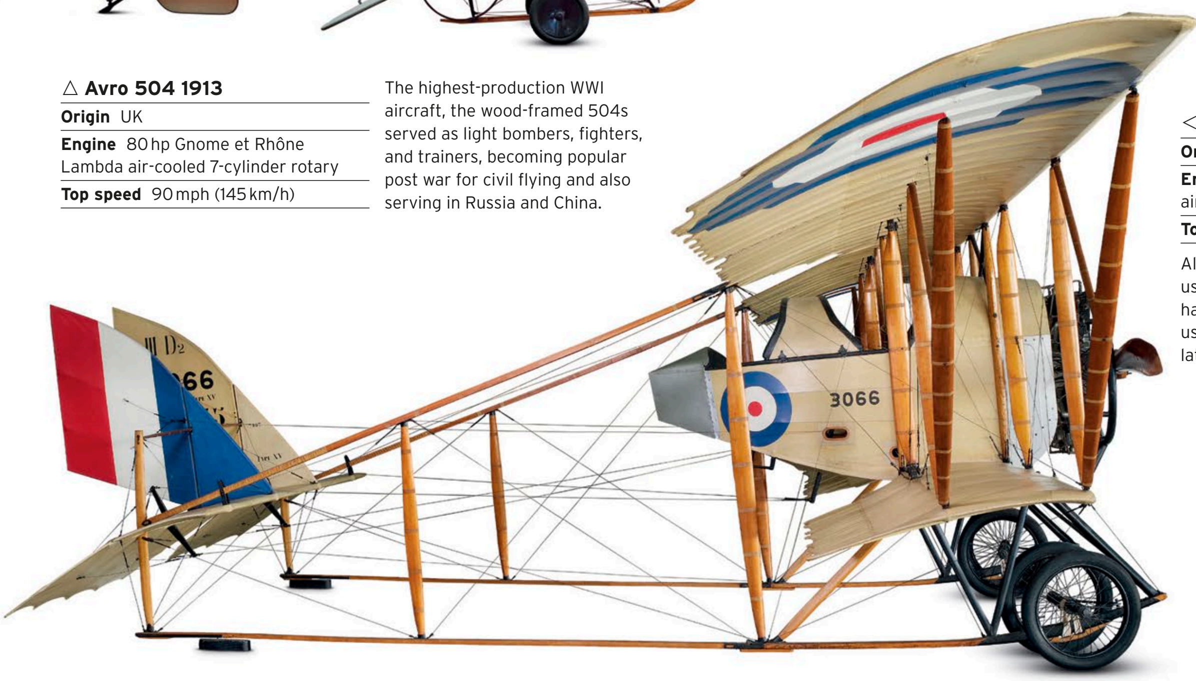
△ Avro 504 1913

Origin UK

Engine 80 hp Gnome et Rhône Lambda air-cooled 7-cylinder rotary

Top speed 90 mph (145 km/h)

The highest-production WWI aircraft, the wood-framed 504s served as light bombers, fighters, and trainers, becoming popular post war for civil flying and also serving in Russia and China.



◁ Caudron G.3 1914

Origin France

Engine 80 hp Le Rhône 9C air-cooled 9-cylinder rotary

Top speed 68 mph (106 km/h)

Although of primitive design, using wing warping, the Caudron had a good rate of climb and was useful for reconnaissance. It was later used for training purposes.

◁ Anatra Anasal DS 1916

Origin Russia

Engine 150 hp Salmson 9U water-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 90 mph (144 km/h)

Manufactured in Odessa with a French Salmson engine built under license, the Anasal was used mostly for reconnaissance by Ukraine, Russia, Austro-Hungary (later Austria and Hungary), and Czechoslovakia.

▷ Bristol F.2B Fighter 1916

Origin UK

Engine 275 hp Rolls-Royce Falcon III water-cooled V12

Top speed 123 mph (198 km/h)

Perfected in this F.2B version, the lively Bristol Fighter held its own against single-seaters and served into the 1930s; shortage of Rolls-Royce engines held back production in WWI.

▷ Sopwith 1½ Strutter 1916

Origin UK

Engine 130 hp Clerget air-cooled 9-cylinder rotary

Top speed 100 mph (161 km/h)

Named after its oddly shaped center section struts, this was an effective fighter and bomber. It was the first British aircraft with a synchronized machine gun for the pilot. It was also built in France.